

Samantha Cervantes

Maxwell School of Citizenship and Public Affairs, Syracuse University

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EDUCATION

Ph.D., Public Administration	2022 – 2027 (expected)
Maxwell School, Syracuse University	
<i>Fields:</i> Education Policy and Urban Policy	
<i>Advisors:</i> Amy Ellen Schwartz and Michah W. Rothbart	
M.S., Applied Economics with Honors	2022
Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM), Mexico City, Mexico	
Certificate in Applied Statistics	2019
Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM), Mexico City, Mexico	
B.A., Business Administration, minor in Political Science	2018
Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM), Mexico City, Mexico	

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Urban Policy, Education Policy, Neighborhood Effects, Economics of Crime

RESEARCH

Job Market Paper

The Impacts of High-Intensity Streetlights on Academic Outcomes: Evidence from a Crime Deterrence Experiment

with Amy Ellen Schwartz

Governments increasingly use place-based interventions to reduce crime, but their consequences for residents, including children, are rarely evaluated beyond crime itself. We study these broader consequences using a 2016 randomized intervention in which the New York Police Department assigned high-intensity streetlights —each emitting 600,000 lumens, four times the brightness of Yankee Stadium’s lights— to high-crime public housing developments. Linking the experimental data to administrative records of public school students and incident-level geocoded crime and arrest data, we find that although exposure to nighttime and daytime index crime, arrests, and incidents involving underage victims fell substantially in high-dose developments, those assigned greater lighting intensity, achievement did not improve on average. This null masks two offsetting patterns. Students in high-rise buildings, where fewer apartments fall within the lights’ reach, gained 0.11 standard deviations in math and 0.10 in reading, while students in low-rise buildings, with a larger fraction of exposed students, lost 0.22 in math, a difference of 0.33 standard deviations. The penalty is largest for the shortest buildings and declines steadily with each additional story. This attenuation with building height is more consistent with direct residential light exposure than with the possibility that students in shorter buildings received smaller crime reductions. The achievement gradient by building height is absent among students living just outside high-dose developments, while no comparable safety gradient by building height appears within them. Instead, consistent with sleep disruption, the losses concentrate among girls at puberty-relevant

ages and in math rather than reading. Differences in post-treatment school mobility and school quality may also account for part of the achievement gradient. A policy can therefore reduce crime while imposing academic costs on the children living closest to it, making its net effect depend on intensity and on how the built environment allocates exposure.

WORKING PAPERS

Hold Harmless for Whom? The Impact of COVID Era Policies for School Funding, Teachers, and Students. (R&R at *Education Finance and Policy*)

with Michah W. Rothbart and Amy Ellen Schwartz

How a Good School in the Neighborhood Affects Academic Outcomes, with Sarah Cordes, Jeehee Han, and Amy Ellen Schwartz

WORKS IN PROGRESS

The Impact of a Crime Deterrence Intervention on Political Behavior, with Ying Shi

Housing Market Responses to Salient Police Interventions: Experimental Evidence from High-Intensity Streetlights, with Alexander Cardazzi

The Long-Term Impacts of Neighborhood Violence on Youth Outcomes, with Amy Ellen Schwartz

PRE-DOCTORAL RESEARCH

The Effect of Public Transit Expansions on Crime: Evidence from Mexico City

RESEARCH AND PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Graduate Research Associate, Center for Policy Research	2022 –
Professors Michah W. Rothbart and Amy Ellen Schwartz, Syracuse University	

Research Assistant, Center for Competitiveness Studies	2019 – 2022
Professor Guillermo Abdel Musik, ITAM	

Investment Consultant, Profuturo Pensiones	2018 – 2019
Mexico City, Mexico	

TEACHING

Syracuse University, MPA Program

Fall 2026 Economics for Public Decisions

Spr 2025 Education Policy, Quantitative Analysis (**Guest Lecturer**)

Spr 2024, 2025 Quantitative Analysis

2023, 2024 Public Budgeting (Intensive Summer Courses)

Fall 2022 Public Budgeting

PRESENTATIONS

Scheduled	Urban Economics Association (UEA); NYU Furman Center; Southern Economics Association (SEA)
2026	American Real Estate and Urban Economics Association (AREUEA); FLX Economics of Education Workshop; Capital District Applied Microeconomics Workshop; Association for Education Finance and Policy (AEFP)
2025	Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management (APPAM)
2024	Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management (APPAM); Association for Education Finance and Policy (AEFP); Public Finance and Budgeting Northeastern Workshop
2023	Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management (APPAM)

GRANTS & AWARDS

First Place, Graduate Student Poster-Session	2026
Center for Policy Research, Syracuse University	
Summer Dissertation Fellowship	
Syracuse University	
Ph.D. Department Research Grant	2025
Syracuse University	
Financial Inclusion Essay Award	2021
National Banking and Securities Commission, Mexico City, Mexico	

SERVICE

Graduate Student Representative, Center for Policy Research	2026 – 2027
Maxwell School, Syracuse University	
Referee: <i>Educational Researcher, Journal of Behavioral Public Administration</i>	

SKILLS

Software: Stata, R, QGIS, Python

Languages: English (fluent), Spanish (native)

REFERENCES

Amy Ellen Schwartz, Professor Emerita of Economics

aeschwar@udel.edu

Michah W. Rothbart, Associate Professor of Public Administration

mwrothba@syr.edu

Ying Shi, Associate Professor of Public Administration

yshi78@syr.edu